General rule – using tools · "Equipment" chapter of SRD 5.2.1

Tools (thieves', forgery, herbalism, navigator's...) enable specific tasks. Each tool states the **ability** used, the **Utilize** action and common **DCs**. If you're proficient with the tool, add your Proficiency Bonus.

If you're proficient in **both the tool and the skill** suited to the task, you have **Advantage**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Pick the tool suited to the task.
2. Roll 1d20 + ability + proficiency (if proficient).
3. Compare to the tool's DC.
4. Tool + skill proficient: **Advantage**.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 lists for each tool its ability, uses and DCs, and clarifies Advantage with tool + skill.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The text doesn't cover every possible use. Fix: the DM sets a consistent DC for unlisted uses.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the precise motion (the pick scraping, the pen gliding) to illustrate the tool.

Step 1 – Choose the tool:

Thieves', forgery, herbalism, etc. You must have it in hand.

Step 2 – Utilize action:

Using a tool is a Utilize action; some uses take longer.

Step 3 – Ability:

The one the tool states (Dex for thieves', Wis for navigator's, etc.).

Step 4 – DC:

See the table: pick a lock DC 15, mimic handwriting DC 15, etc.

Step 5 – Advantage:

If proficient in the tool and the suited skill, Advantage.

Example: Mira (Thieves' Tools + Sleight of Hand) picks a DC 15 lock with Advantage.

Tool	Common use
Thieves' Tools	Dex: pick a lock or disarm a trap, DC 15
Forgery Kit	Dex: mimic handwriting, DC 15
Disguise Kit	Cha: create a disguise, DC 10
Herbalism Kit	Int or Wis: prepare a potion or antidote
Navigator's Tools	Wis: plot a course, DC 15
Poisoner's Kit	Int: prepare a poison
Tinker's Tools	Int: repair an item
Artisan's Tools	Craft items of the trade

⚠ Common questions:

Must I be proficient with the tool?

No, but you don't add proficiency without it.

Tool + skill?

If proficient in both: Advantage.

How long?

The Utilize action; crafting takes days.

Can I use an improvised tool?

Yes, with Disadvantage at the DM's call.

Do thieves' tools disarm traps?

Yes, usually Dex DC 15.

And forgery?

Dex DC 15 to mimic handwriting.

Crafting?

Depends on time and material cost.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Improvised tools

Can I replace a tool? **Option**: Disadvantage.

Crafting

Time and cost to craft. **Option**: one day per 50 gp.

Partial proficiency

Proficiency in a tool category. **Option**: one proficiency only.

Variable DC

DC by context. **Option**: DC 10 to 20.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Utilize

Each tool use is a Utilize action.

Suited skill

The skill must match the task (Sleight of Hand to pick locks).

Advantage

Tool and skill proficiency: Advantage.

DC

SRD DCs are benchmarks; the DM can adjust them.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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